



PHOTOS BY CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Vehicles drive over the Salang Pass, near Baghlan on the road between Kabul and Ishkashim in northeastern Afghanistan.

Taliban dreams of a highway to the future

Afghan regime plans to put itself at the center of commerce by building a connection with China

BY RICK NOACK AND CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN
IN ISHKASHIM, AFGHANISTAN



A Taliban official stands on the side of a mountain in Baghlan. Taliban officials have a plan to build a highway through the Wakhan Corridor, the panhandle in the far northeast that's one of the country's remotest areas.

More than three years after the Taliban seized power, Afghanistan remains economically decrepit and politically isolated. But now, the Taliban government has a plan to turn one of the country's remotest corners into a global trade hub.

The regime wants to build a highway through the Wakhan Corridor, the narrow, rugged panhandle in the far northeast, to connect the Afghan heartland with China — and place itself at the center of international commerce.

If the road is ever completed, it would bypass Pakistan, dramatically cutting travel times between Central Asia and China and potentially promoting trade in rare minerals and other resources, such as lithium, cobalt

and gold. The highway's boosters see it returning Afghanistan to the central place it held ages ago on the Silk Road, as China pushes forward with plans to build a modern version of the route with an intercontinental network of land and maritime routes. "Wakhan is part of it," said Abdul Salam Jawad, a spokesman for the Taliban-run Ministry of Industry and Commerce.

The Taliban says its initial task is to pave a 30-mile stretch of dirt road just west of the Chinese border, though 200 more miles are also largely unpaved and badly in need of improvement. Ultimately, the route will require building durable bridges and eliminating river crossings that

SEE AFGHANISTAN ON A16

Trump enacts tariffs on U.S. trade partners

CANADA, MEXICO, CHINA LEVIES THIS WEEK

Southern, northern neighbors vow a response

BY DAVID J. LYNCH

President Donald Trump on Saturday imposed tariffs on imports from Canada, Mexico and China, the nation's three largest trading partners, invoking emergency economic powers in a high-stakes bid to compel them to crack down on illegal immigration and drugs reaching the United States.

The president signed three executive orders establishing the measures, the first official actions of his second-term trade war, according to a White House official who briefed reporters.

They drew sharp replies from the leaders of Canada and Mexico, as well as immediate opposition from business and labor groups, which warned of profound upheaval throughout the economy. For the typical U.S.

household, the tariffs will mean a loss of about \$1,200 in annual purchasing power, according to the Budget Lab at Yale University, a nonpartisan research center.

Effective Tuesday at 12:01 a.m. Eastern time, American importers will pay a new 25 percent tax on goods from Canada and Mexico and a 10 percent levy on products from China, the president said. Most products from Canada and Mexico currently face no tariffs, under a trade deal Trump signed during his first term, while many Chinese goods incur taxes of up to 25 percent. The new tariffs are in addition to those fees.

Energy products, including crude oil from Canada, will suffer a 10 percent charge.

If any of the three countries retaliate with their own tariffs on

SEE TARIFFS ON A7

Maduro agrees to accept deportees who fled his authoritarian regime

BY SAMANTHA SCHMIDT, PETER JAMISON AND MARIA SACCHETTI

The government of Nicolás Maduro will take in Venezuelans who are deported by the United States, President Donald Trump said Saturday, potentially clearing the way for hundreds of thousands of immigrants from the South American country to be sent back to the authoritarian socialist regime that many fled.

The Trump administration has said it is prioritizing the return of criminals and gang members, but the deportees

could eventually include hundreds of thousands of Venezuelans with temporary protected status that is set to expire later this year.

"Venezuela has agreed to receive, back into their Country, all Venezuela illegal aliens who were encamped in the U.S., including gang members of Tren de Aragua," Trump wrote Saturday morning on Truth Social. "Venezuela has further agreed to supply the transportation back."

SEE VENEZUELA ON A15

Rubio: Secretary of state heads to Panama with a brazen mandate. **A8**

Hamas releases U.S. hostage as ceasefire continues to hold

Rafah border crossing with Egypt reopens for medical evacuations

BY CLAIRE PARKER, JOANNA SLATER, ELLEN FRANCIS AND ALON ROM

JERUSALEM — Hamas released U.S. citizen Keith Siegel in the fourth round of hostages-for-prisoners exchanges under the Gaza ceasefire with Israel, and the Rafah crossing to Egypt reopened for the first time in eight months to allow medical evacuations.

Siegel, 65, a citizen of the United States and Israel, and two Israeli men — Ofer Kalderon, 54, and Yarden Bibas, 35 — were freed Saturday morning after 15 months in captivity in tightly choreographed handover ceremonies at two sites in Gaza. Their transfers were more orderly than previous releases.

Israel released 183 Palestinians, according to Wafa, the Palestinian Authority's official news agency. They included 111 who were detained in Gaza by the Israeli military after Oct. 7, 2023, and held without trial in prisons where freed detainees and rights

groups advocates say they've been subject to frequent abuse and violence.

Also Saturday, medical and humanitarian officials began evacuating the first group of seriously ill or wounded patients through the Rafah crossing with Egypt since it was closed by Israeli forces in May.

That reopening and the fourth round of exchanges showed the shaky ceasefire is holding, after months of fraught, frustrating negotiations.

Hamas-led fighters launched a surprise attack on southern Israel on Oct. 7, 2023, killing 1,200 people and taking 250 others back to Gaza as hostages. Israel responded with a military campaign to eradicate Hamas that has killed more than 47,000 people inside the enclave.

Siegel was raised in North Carolina but migrated to Israel as a young man and acquired Israeli citizenship. Siegel and his wife, Aviva, lived in Kibbutz Kfar Aza. Aviva, who was also kidnapped from their home Oct. 7, was released during a ceasefire in November 2023.

Kalderon was kidnapped from his home in Kibbutz Nir Oz along with his children, Sahar and

SEE EXCHANGE ON A24

Ceasefire: Skies quiet, Gazans search for water, food, shelter. **A18**

The lives that were lost: Family and friends remember victims of the collision between American Eagle Flight 5342 and an Army helicopter near Reagan National Airport. **A12-13**



A trip steeped in joy for the family of a young figure skater ends in tragedy

BY TEO ARMUS

Brielle Beyer and her mother, Justyna, who were killed in the crash of American Eagle Flight 5342.

Helicopter traffic:

Airport has long struggled to cope, records show. **A9**

The trip to Wichita was supposed to be the best one yet for Brielle and Justyna Beyer.

The mother-daughter pair had traveled from their home in Northern Virginia to Kansas for a training program for the country's best young figure skaters — a small, elite group that now included Brielle.

It was a major achievement for the 12-year-old, who despite a

cancer diagnosis as a baby had worked to become one of the top girls in her age group nationally. So, too, for Justyna, 42, who left behind her nursing career to care for her daughter and then support her dreams on the ice.

For six days in Kansas, they watched with awe as older skaters competed in the national championships. They fueled up

SEE VICTIMS ON A10

METRO
Trump could transform D.C. real estate, from downtown to design.

SPORTS
Vintage: Hall of Famer Charles Woodson has his own wine brand.



ARTS & STYLE
Betty Gilpin, on TV or on stage, is the best part of the show you love.

BUSINESS
Federal workers should tell Trump "no deal," Michelle Singletary says.



BOOK WORLD
Two books argue that our capacity for connection has been devastated.

TRAVEL
The DCA crash reminds fliers of the perils and miracles of air travel.

\$150 SUNDAY COUPON INSERTS

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post / Year 148, No. 54115

